UPFRONT

GRAPHIC: THE WAR OF WAR CHESTS *PG 12*

VIEWPOINT: GEN-Z REGIME IN NEPAL *PG 19*



AFP

ESCALATION WORRIES Smoke billows from a Thai bulk carrier after an attack in the Strait of Hormuz on Mar. 11

▶ IRAN CONFLICT

BRACING FOR AN ENERGY SQUEEZE

War-driven disruptions in global oil and gas markets push India to secure supplies and manage costs

By M.G. ARUN

ON MARCH 8, OIL PRICES BRIEFLY SURGED PAST A PSYCHOLOGICAL threshold that had not been breached since the early days of the Russia-Ukraine war in 2022. Brent crude prices climbed above $100 (about Rs 9,200) a barrel as the conflict in West Asia escalated sharply, and have remained highly volatile since. Cargo movement through the Strait of Hormuz—one of the world's most critical energy arteries linking the Persian Gulf to the Gulf of Oman—has been severely disrupted after the US and Israel launched strikes on Iran on February 28, prompting retaliatory attacks on Tel Aviv as well as US military locations, refineries and civilian infrastructure across the Gulf nations.

Even without a formal blockade, warnings from militant groups that vessels passing